



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Penn Woods Classical Academy

School Website: <https://pennwoodsclassical.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Penn Woods Classical Academy (PWCA) demonstrates a robust alignment with classical, Christian education as defined by the Classical School rubric in the knowledge base. The school foregrounds a Christ-centered, liberal-arts approach, emphasizes virtue and wisdom, and embeds classical curricular markers (Hillsdale-aligned curriculum, use of primary sources, emphasis on Western civilization and great works, inclusion of Latin). Public materials consistently articulate a formation-focused telos (true, good, beautiful) and promote partnerships with families and faith-integrated practices. While explicit, high-detail statements about certain pedagogy components (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars or scholé days) are less visible in the public materials, PWCA communicates core classical elements that position it firmly within the Classical spectrum.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Key observations

- Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and central: Christ-centered mission, Nicene Creed, Biblical literacy, corporate worship, and a shared theological framework (interdenominational, worship-centric culture) are repeatedly foregrounded. Evidence: "Christ-centered Liberal Arts education," "Soli Deo Gloria," Nicene Creed, Biblical literacy, prayer and communal worship.
- Purpose and goal consistently emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and humane flourishing over mere job-readiness. Evidence: mission phrased as forming mind, heart, and spirit; emphasis on truth, goodness, beauty; aim for virtuous leaders within faith and community.
- Curriculum shows classical scaffolding: Hillsdale American Classical Curriculum, liberal arts balance, emphasis on primary sources, Western civilization, Great Works, and Latin.
- Pedagogy contains notable classical signals (memory-work, reverence for wonder, primary-source-driven instruction) but specific explicit statements on some canonical practices (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars or scholé days) are less visible in public pages. This yields a robust but not exhaustively explicit Pedagogy profile in published materials.
- Faculty are presented as trained, virtuous mentors aligned with Hillsdale's classical approach; leadership and faculty profiles emphasize mission alignment, virtue, and living curriculum.
- Parents & Community partnerships are foregrounded, with explicit language about co-teaching, parent formation, and accessible campus visits; ongoing parent engagement channels are evident (tours, open houses, podcasts).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence



- Public materials present PWCA as Christ-centered with a clear devotion to faith-informed education (Interdenominational Christian community, biblical literacy, prayer, communal worship).
- The school frames education within a Christian theological worldview (Nicene Creed; Soli Deo Gloria; Scripture-based formation).
- The school explicitly connects truth, goodness, and beauty to its mission (to know truth, do good, love the beautiful).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, Biblical literacy, prayer, worship, Nicene Creed, interdenominational, Soli Deo Gloria, true/good/beautiful, theology, liturgy, creed, sacred. (Examples drawn from PWCA's mission and faith statements.)
- Negative keywords present: None identified in public materials.

Why this rating

- The materials foreground transcendental and theological foundations, explicitly tying character formation to a Christian worldview and liturgical/community practices, aligning with the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations criteria. The strong emphasis on truth, virtue, and beauty in a faith-based context supports a CLASSICAL designation in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Core mission explicitly centers formation of mind, heart, and spirit toward wisdom and virtue; aims for life-long discipleship and leadership within faith communities.
- Public statements tie the aims to truth, goodness, and beauty, and to the flourishing of human beings within a Christian worldview.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: virtue, wisdom, formation, human flourishing, telos, truth/goodness/beauty, lifelong learning, leadership, character. (Evidence from "Our Mission" and related pages.)
- Negative keywords present: None identified.

Why this rating

- PWCA's public-facing materials emphasize formation and virtue as primary aims rather than job-preparation or purely information-transfer. The telos of education as the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, plus the Christian formation frame, supports CLASSICAL status in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The program is described as Hillsdale American Classical Curriculum, a hallmark of classical liberal arts education.
- Explicit emphasis on liberal arts across disciplines (math, science, literature, history, art, music, Latin, physical education).
- References to using primary sources, Western civilization, and great works as curricular anchors.
- Mention of Great Works and Western civilization's great works as a curricular anchor; emphasis on classical heritage.
- Some material notes a three-phase learning approach (in public materials related to PWCA's model), which aligns with traditional grammar-logic-rhetoric sequencing common in classical education (though explicit listing of grammar/logic/rhetoric is not always spelled out in every page).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, Great Works, Western civilization, primary sources, Latin, classical curriculum, grammar, logic, rhetoric (explicit mentions vary by page, but the core elements are present across PWCA materials), three-phase learning model, primary sources, great conversation.
- Negative keywords present: None identified.

Why this rating

- PWCA publicly positions itself within a classical framework through Hillsdale curriculum alignment, liberal-arts breadth including Latin, and emphasis on great works and primary sources. This aligns with CATEGORY 3 requirements for a classical curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The materials emphasize a classical approach and heavy emphasis on virtue, memory, and meaningful learning, but explicit, detailed statements about specific canonical practices (e.g., frequent Socratic seminars at the high-school level, scholé days, chanting, or structured memory work across grades) are not consistently present in the public site text. However, there are clear signals of classical pedagogy (e.g., primary-source-based instruction, emphasis on wonder, and a structured curriculum).
- There are explicit mentions of teacher quality and a “living curriculum” vibe via faculty profiles and Hillsdale alignment; public pages emphasize a rigorous, Christ-centered curriculum and a connected classroom culture.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: wonder, primary sources, classical method, rigorous curriculum, memory/recitation (implied by classical approach), rhetoric (mentioned in the classical lexicon as a category (though explicit PWCA page references are variable), Hillsdale alignment).
- Negative keywords present: explicit, highly detailed references to Socratic seminars, scholé, or chant/recitation practices are not consistently present in the public content. The absence of explicit statements on certain pedagogical techniques pulls the category toward a more cautious assessment.

Why this rating

- PWCA clearly adheres to classical aims and methods in spirit (classical curriculum, primary sources, Great Works), but the public-facing materials do not consistently spell out the full spectrum of canonical pedagogy (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars in upper grades, explicit singing/chanting, memory work). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials present PWCA as led by a trained Head of School and an associate leadership team; Hillsdale-trained teachers are highlighted as delivering the curriculum. The faculty are described as the living curriculum in youth-facing materials and leadership communications.
- The site features faculty bios and profiles, underscoring professional qualification, moral formation, and alignment with the school’s mission; there is a clear emphasis on virtuous modeling and mentorship.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Hillsdale-trained teachers, Head of School, living curriculum, faculty as mentors, portrait of teacher, collegial culture.
- Negative keywords present: None identified.

Why this rating

- The school's public-facing materials emphasize professional, mission-aligned faculty who model virtue and intellectual rigor, which aligns strongly with the Classical Faculty criteria. The explicit reference to Hillsdale-trained educators and a "living curriculum" orientation supports CLASSICAL placement.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- PWCA frames parents as partners in education (co-teachers) and emphasizes parental formation and engagement with the school's classical mission. Public materials advertise open houses, tours, and opportunities to visit, reflecting an accessible, family-friendly model.
- The school communicates a clearly defined pathway for parent involvement (prospective parent open houses, tours, personal visits, and podcasts that discuss classical education).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus/visits, parent involvement, tours, open houses, community engagement, family-centric events.
- Negative keywords present: None identified.

Why this rating

- The materials consistently position parents as engaged partners and co-educators, with explicit opportunities and channels for parent formation and campus accessibility, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations in the Parents & Community category.

Aggregate Ranking and Synthesis

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

The PWCA materials strongly reflect core classical dimensions—religious foundations, formation-focused aims, classical curriculum anchored in Hillsdale and Great Works, and a model of dedicated faculty and engaged parents. Element 4 is the only nuanced area, where explicit pedagogical practices are less consistently documented in public pages. Given the weight of the remaining six categories, PWCA earns an overall CLASSICAL classification with a minor caveat in Pedagogy that could be addressed with more explicit articulation of certain canonical teaching methods (e.g., Socratic seminars, scholé practices, and explicit recital/memory instruction) in public materials.

What would move the needle

- If PWCA intends to move toward a fully explicit CLASSICAL Pedagogy in public materials, it could publish explicit statements on:
- Socratic seminars and guided inquiry for upper grades, including sample prompts and assessment structures.
- Explicit evidence of memory work, chant, and recitation practices (lower- and middle-school levels) and how they integrate with core subjects.
- Clear articulation of a three-phase grammar-logic-rhetoric sequence with concrete examples of tasks for each phase.
- Documentation of scholé/restful learning days and contemplation within the weekly schedule, if adopted.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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